

# Childcare Prices: Milestone 3

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**Course:** DSC640

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## Medium Overview

The combined mediums were designed to keep the message consistent while adjusting the format to fit how each medium would be used. Across the infographic, dashboard, and presentation, I used a restrained, blue-based color palette to create visual continuity and to support a calm, credible tone that fits a childcare cost topic rather than making it feel overly dramatic. The visual hierarchy was intentionally simple, with larger headings, short section titles, and consistent spacing so viewers could move through the content quickly without getting lost. The dashboard uses a clean card layout, grouped filters, and clear summary metrics so working parents can locate their county, compare provider types, and interpret results without needing technical knowledge. The infographic uses a vertical layout with separated content bands so the main findings, age pattern, provider gap, geography, budget burden, and limitations can be scanned in sequence as a one-page summary. The presentation uses one main takeaway per slide and supporting charts with minimal clutter so the audience can focus on the story instead of reading dense text. In all three mediums, chart choices were selected for clarity rather than novelty. Bar charts, comparison charts, and simple trend displays make the data easier to interpret for a general audience. I also included visible notes on data limitations and imputation so the visuals remain transparent and ethically grounded. Together, these design choices support readability, consistency, and an explanatory story that leads the audience from evidence to action.

# Childcare Costs Hit Hardest in the Early Years

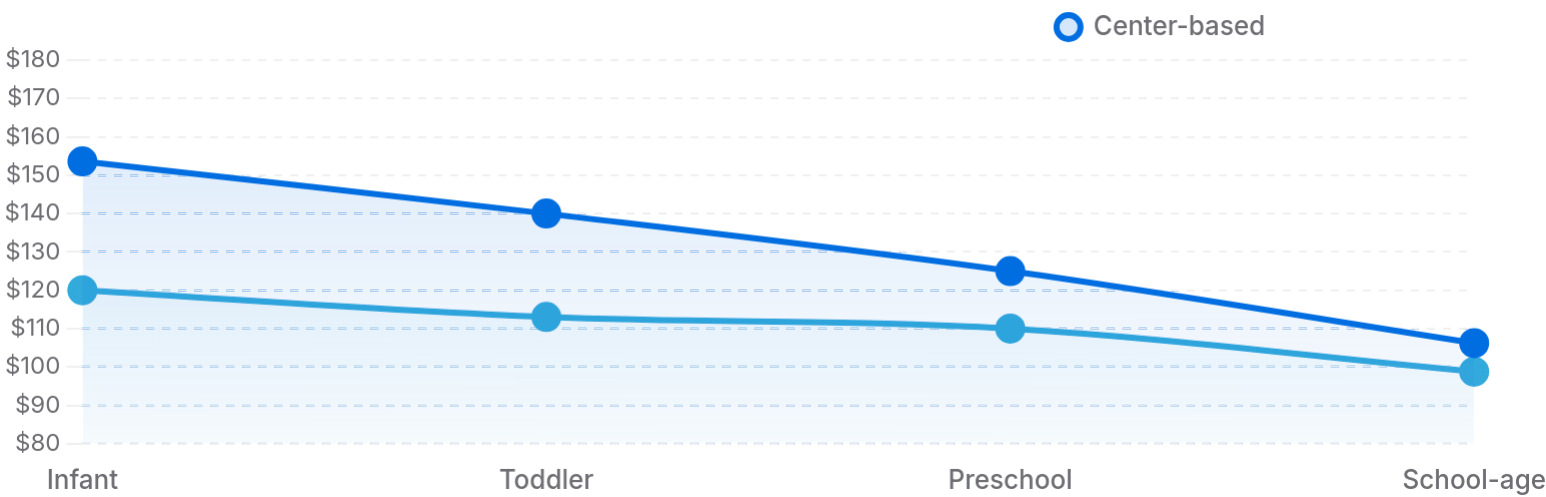
Weekly full-time childcare prices are highest for infants and toddlers, typically higher in centers than family childcare, and vary significantly across counties.

Source: U.S. Department of Labor Women's Bureau — National Database of Childcare Prices, 2018 county-level estimates.

SECTION 1 · AGE PATH

## Weekly prices are highest at the beginning

Across 2018 county estimates, the median weekly price for center-based care drops from **\$153.60** for infants to **\$106.22** for school-age children. Family childcare follows the same pattern, falling from **\$120.00** to **\$98.77**.

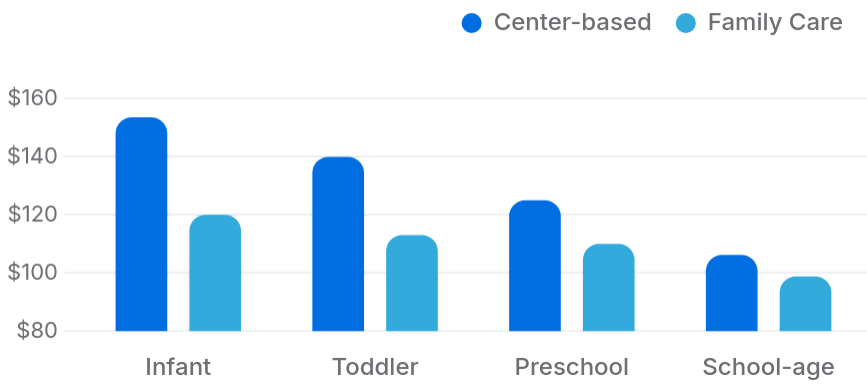


**Key insight:** Center-based infant care is about **31% higher** than center-based school-age care — the early years carry the steepest price tag.

SECTION 2 · PROVIDER TYPE

## Center-based care usually costs more

At every age group, center-based care exceeds family childcare. The gap is widest for infants.

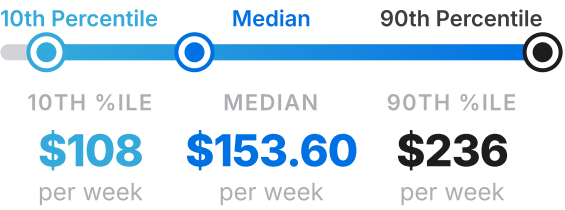


|           |               |            |               |
|-----------|---------------|------------|---------------|
| Infant    | +\$33.60 / wk | Toddler    | +\$26.96 / wk |
| Preschool | +\$15.00 / wk | School-age | +\$7.45 / wk  |

SECTION 3 · GEOGRAPHY

## Where you live changes what families pay

For center-based infant care in 2018, county-level prices ranged dramatically from the 10th to the 90th percentile.



**\$128/week spread** between the lowest and highest county bands — childcare cost is a **location issue**, not just a family budgeting issue.

SECTION 4 · BUDGET BURDEN

## Why this matters for working parents

Using county median household income as a rough local context measure, infant childcare in 2018 consumed a significant share of estimated weekly household income at the median county.

16.1%

of estimated weekly median household income  
Center-based infant care

12.5%

of estimated weekly median household income  
Family infant care

*Note: These figures use county-level median household income only as rough local context — not a direct household affordability measure. The dataset does not include household-level income data.*

### What this data does not show

These data show prices, not whether childcare slots are available. They also do not include informal care from relatives or friends, and some values were standardized or imputed during dataset construction.

### Use local numbers to advocate

Plan ahead for the early-years cost spike. Use local childcare price data when asking employers about flexible schedules, dependent-care support, or other family benefits. Share the numbers with local leaders when childcare costs create barriers to work.



## Childcare Prices Dashboard

Weekly full-time childcare prices from the National Database of Childcare Prices. This dashboard is designed for working parents who want quick local cost context by age, provider type, and year.

Audience: Working parents

Focus: Age, provider type, and location

Call to action: Use local numbers when asking for flexibility, benefits, or childcare support

### FILTERS

Choose a state, county, year, provider type, price view, and age focus

#### State

Alabama

#### County

Autauga County

#### Year

2018

#### Provider type

Center-based

#### Price view

Median

#### Age group focus

Infant (0-23m)

☒ Show imputation and aggregation notes

County median household income is shown only as budget context. It is not the same as a household budget for any one family.

Selected weekly price

**\$120**

Center-based, Median, Infant (0-23m), 2018

Monthly estimate

**\$521**

Weekly price x 4.33

County median household income

**\$58,786**

County-level annual context

Cost share of weekly income proxy

**10.7%**

Selected weekly price divided by annual MHI / 52

### LOCATION IN STATE CONTEXT

Selected county compared with other counties in the same state for the same setting

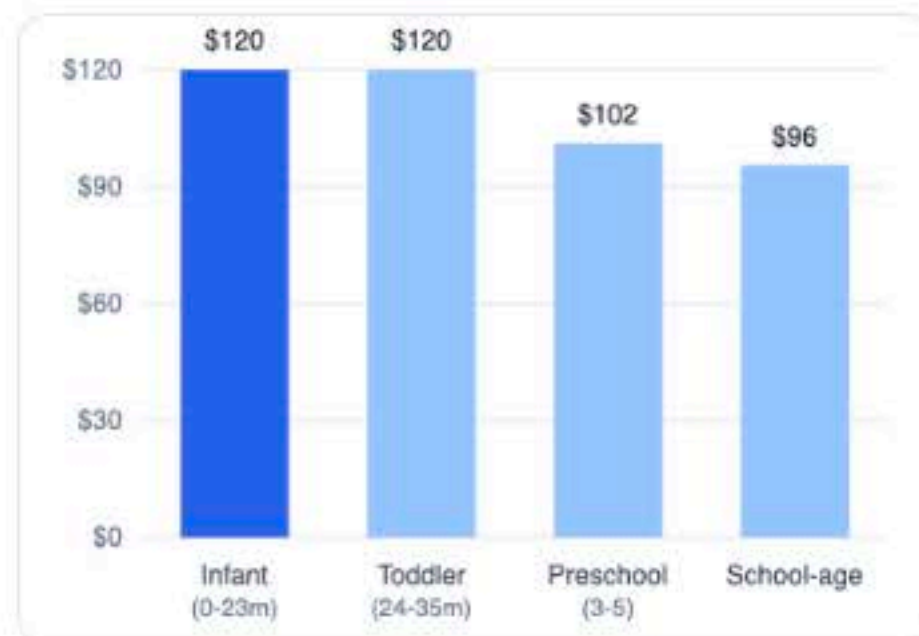
Autauga County, AL



Autauga County is ranked #36 out of 67 counties in Alabama for the selected year, provider type, price view, and age group.

### PRICE BY AGE GROUP

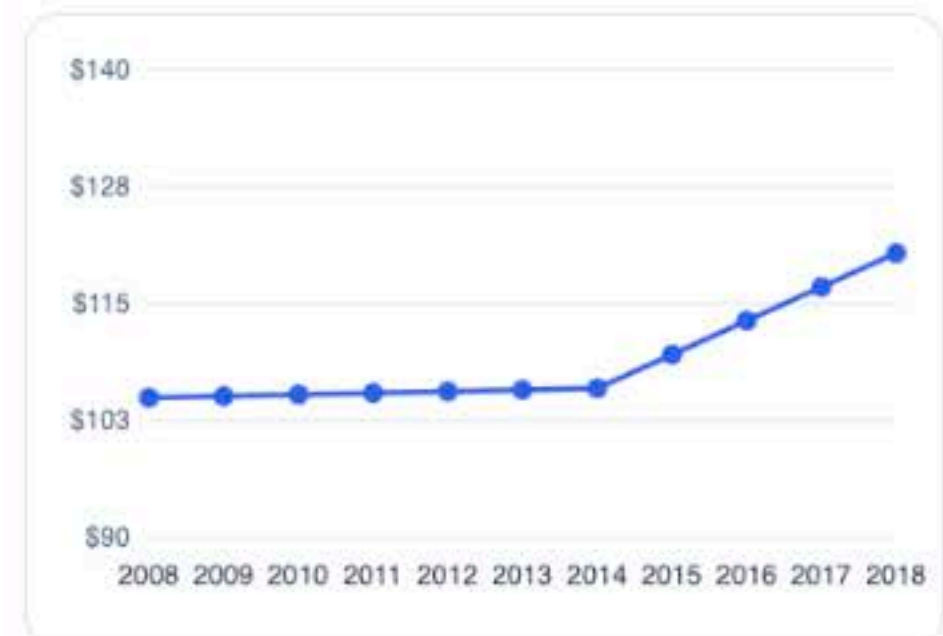
Weekly prices across ages for the selected county, year, provider, and price view



Use this view to see how costs usually step down from infancy to school age.

### TREND OVER TIME

Selected age group's weekly price across available years in the selected county



The line only shows years where the selected county has a value for this exact setting.

### INTERPRETATION PANEL

Plain-language context for working parents

- Infant (0-23m) costs about \$120 per week in Autauga County for 2018 under the selected setting.
- Within this county and setting, infant care is about \$24 more per week than school-age care.
- Center-based is about \$13 more per week than family-based for Infant (0-23m).

### CALL TO ACTION

Bring your county's numbers to your employer, school board, or local leaders when asking for dependent-care benefits, flexible schedules, and childcare support.

### DATA NOTE FOR THE SELECTED VALUE

One or more component prices used for this value were imputed in the source data. This broad age value matched all underlying age-band prices. Use the household income metric only as county-level context, not as an estimate of any one family's budget.

Source: U.S. Department of Labor, Women's Bureau National Database of Childcare Prices. Values are standardized to weekly full-time prices.



## Childcare Prices Dashboard

Weekly full-time childcare prices from the National Database of Childcare Prices. This dashboard is designed for working parents who want quick local cost context by age, provider type, and year.

Audience: Working parents

Focus: Age, provider type, and location

Call to action: Use local numbers when asking for flexibility, benefits, or childcare support

### FILTERS

Choose a state, county, year, provider type, price view, and age focus

#### State

Alabama

#### County

Autauga County

#### Year

2018

#### Provider type

Family-based

#### Price view

Median

#### Age group focus

Infant (0-23m)

☒ Show imputation and aggregation notes

County median household income is shown only as budget context. It is not the same as a household budget for any one family.

Selected weekly price

**\$107**

Family-based, Median, Infant (0-23m), 2018

Monthly estimate

**\$464**

Weekly price x 4.33

County median household income

**\$58,786**

County-level annual context

Cost share of weekly income proxy

**9.5%**

Selected weekly price divided by annual MHI / 52

### LOCATION IN STATE CONTEXT

Selected county compared with other counties in the same state for the same setting

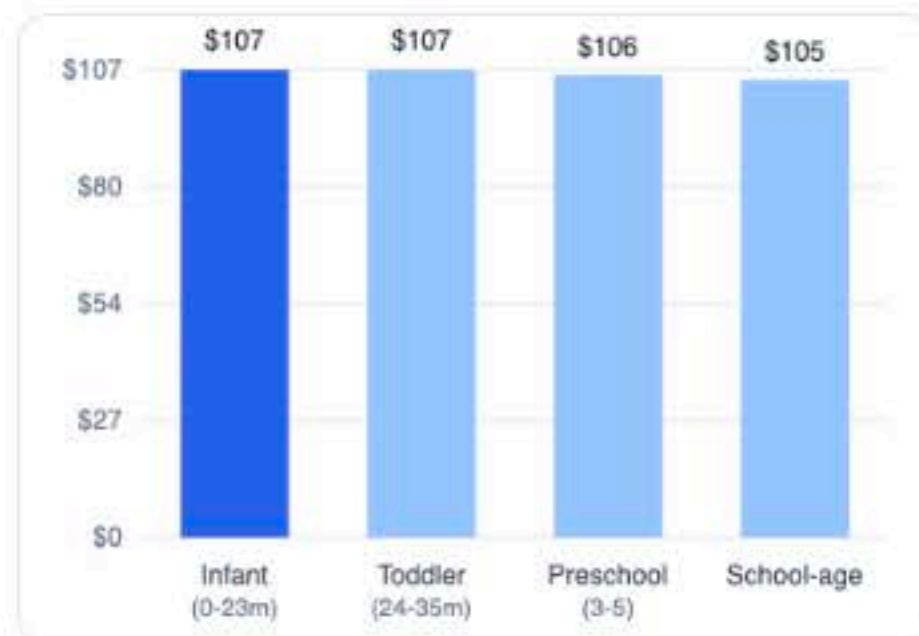
Autauga County, AL



Autauga County is ranked #36 out of 67 counties in Alabama for the selected year, provider type, price view, and age group.

### PRICE BY AGE GROUP

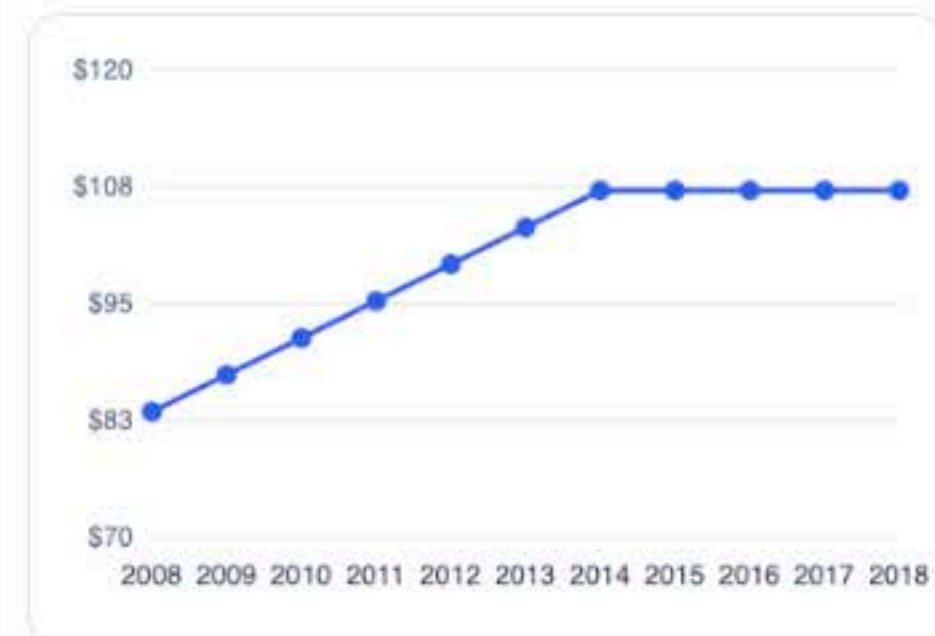
Weekly prices across ages for the selected county, year, provider, and price view



Use this view to see how costs usually step down from infancy to school age.

### TREND OVER TIME

Selected age group's weekly price across available years in the selected county



The line only shows years where the selected county has a value for this exact setting.

### INTERPRETATION PANEL

Plain-language context for working parents

- Infant (0-23m) costs about \$107 per week in Autauga County for 2018 under the selected setting.
- Within this county and setting, infant care is about \$2 more per week than school-age care.
- Family-based is about \$13 less per week than center-based for Infant (0-23m).

### CALL TO ACTION

Bring your county's numbers to your employer, school board, or local leaders when asking for dependent-care benefits, flexible schedules, and childcare support.

### DATA NOTE FOR THE SELECTED VALUE

One or more component prices used for this value were imputed in the source data. This broad age value matched all underlying age-band prices. Use the household income metric only as county-level context, not as an estimate of any one family's budget.

Source: U.S. Department of Labor, Women's Bureau National Database of Childcare Prices. Values are standardized to weekly full-time prices.



## Childcare Prices Dashboard

Weekly full-time childcare prices from the National Database of Childcare Prices. This dashboard is designed for working parents who want quick local cost context by age, provider type, and year.

Audience: Working parents

Focus: Age, provider type, and location

Call to action: Use local numbers when asking for flexibility, benefits, or childcare support

### FILTERS

Choose a state, county, year, provider type, price view, and age focus

#### State

Alabama

#### County

Jefferson County

#### Year

2018

#### Provider type

Family-based

#### Price view

Median

#### Age group focus

Preschool (3-5)

☒ Show imputation and aggregation notes

County median household income is shown only as budget context. It is not the same as a household budget for any one family.

Selected weekly price

**\$112**

Family-based, Median, Preschool (3-5), 2018

Monthly estimate

**\$485**

Weekly price x 4.33

County median household income

**\$51,979**

County-level annual context

Cost share of weekly income proxy

**11.2%**

Selected weekly price divided by annual MHI / 52

### LOCATION IN STATE CONTEXT

Selected county compared with other counties in the same state for the same setting

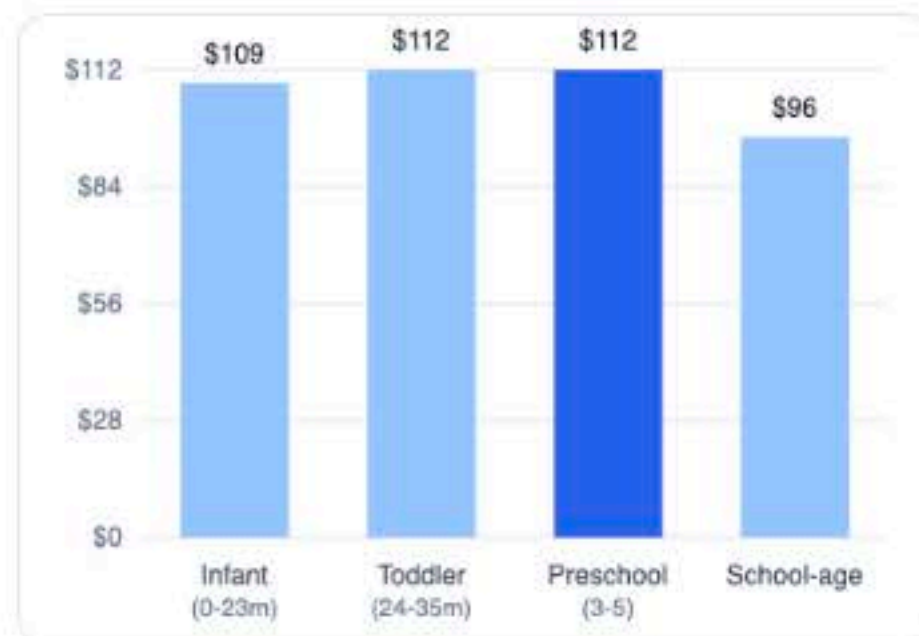
Jefferson County, AL



Jefferson County is ranked #17 out of 67 counties in Alabama for the selected year, provider type, price view, and age group.

### PRICE BY AGE GROUP

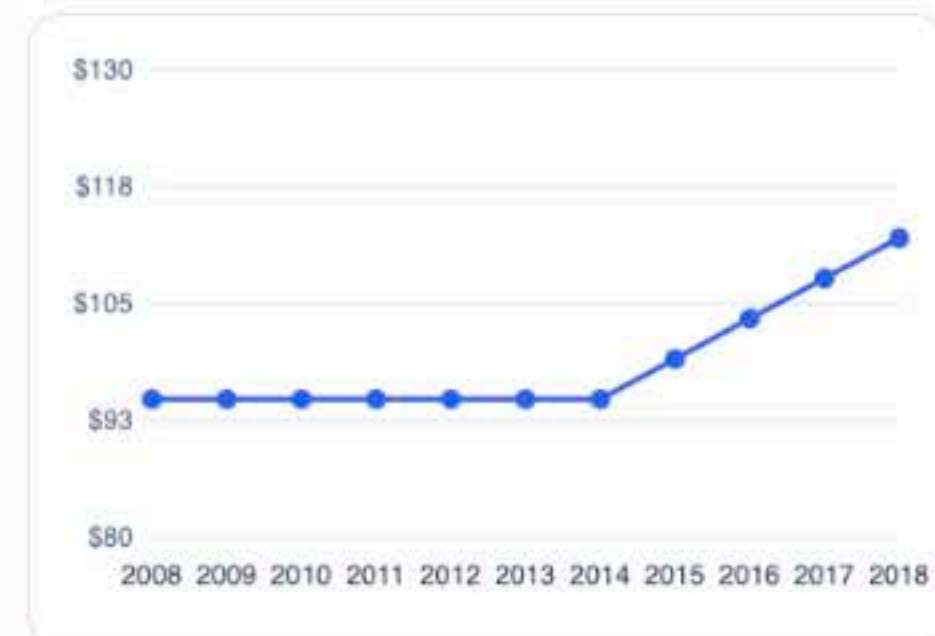
Weekly prices across ages for the selected county, year, provider, and price view



Use this view to see how costs usually step down from infancy to school age.

### TREND OVER TIME

Selected age group's weekly price across available years in the selected county



The line only shows years where the selected county has a value for this exact setting.

### INTERPRETATION PANEL

Plain-language context for working parents

- Preschool (3-5) costs about \$112 per week in Jefferson County for 2018 under the selected setting.
- Within this county and setting, infant care is about \$13 more per week than school-age care.
- Family-based is about \$43 less per week than center-based for Preschool (3-5).

### CALL TO ACTION

Bring your county's numbers to your employer, school board, or local leaders when asking for dependent-care benefits, flexible schedules, and childcare support.

### DATA NOTE FOR THE SELECTED VALUE

One or more component prices used for this value were imputed in the source data. This broad age value matched all underlying age-band prices. Use the household income metric only as county-level context, not as an estimate of any one family's budget.

Source: U.S. Department of Labor, Women's Bureau National Database of Childcare Prices. Values are standardized to weekly full-time prices.



# Childcare Prices Change Fast in the Early Years

A COUNTY-LEVEL LOOK AT  
WEEKLY FULL-TIME  
CHILDCARE PRICES IN 2018

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MSDS, BELLEVUE UNIVERSITY

DSC 640: DATA PRESENTATION AND  
VISUALIZATION

INSTRUCTOR: BENJAMIN SCHNEIDER

MAR 8, 2026



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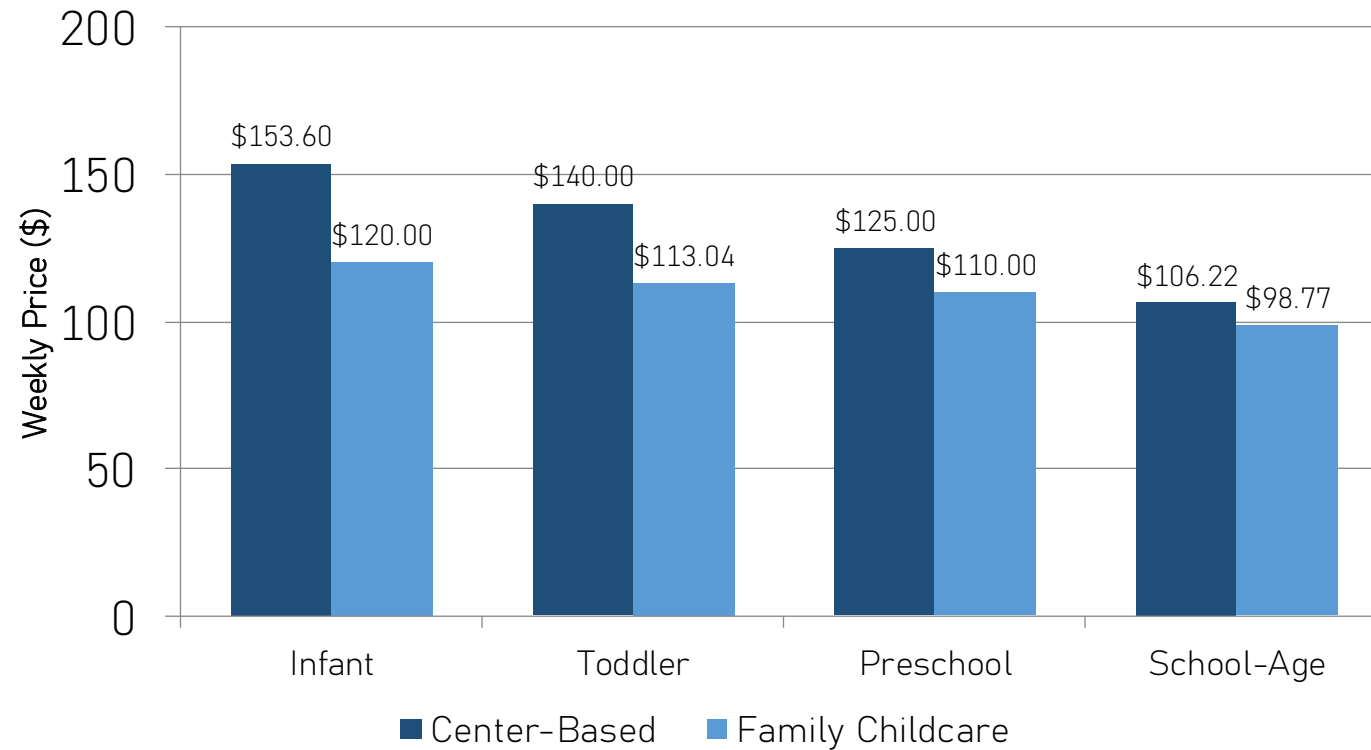
# What the Data Measures

- County-level weekly childcare price estimates
- Four age groups: infant, toddler, preschool, and school-age
- Two provider types: center-based and family childcare
- Main story year shown here: 2018
- Data spans 2008 to 2018 across U.S. counties
- 3,142 counties in 2018; price data available for 2,360 (center-based) and 2,348 (family)

Note: Prices are standardized to a weekly basis, and some values are imputed or derived during dataset construction (U.S. DOL Women's Bureau, 2020).



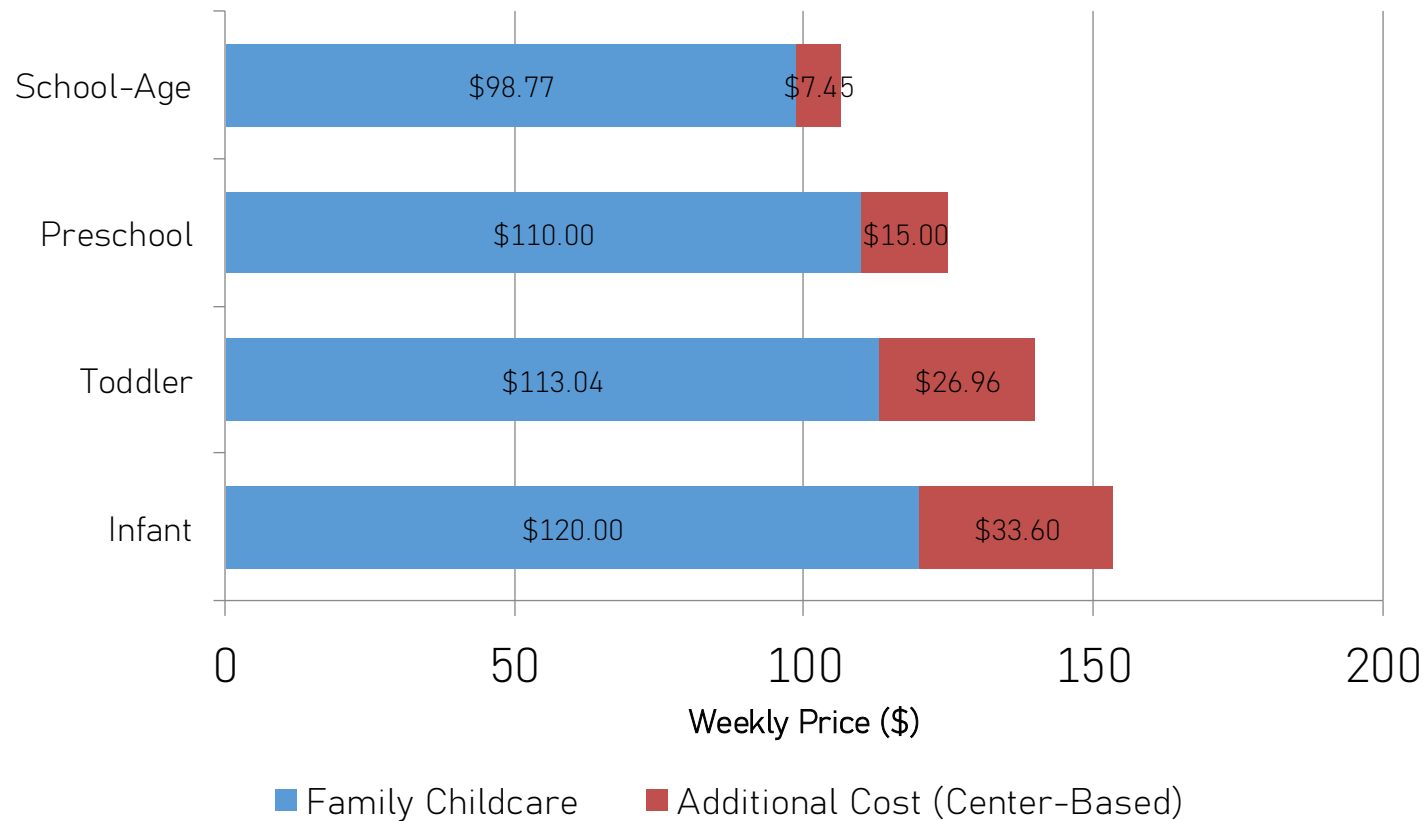
# The Earliest Years Cost the Most



- Median weekly childcare prices by age group at the median county, 2018*

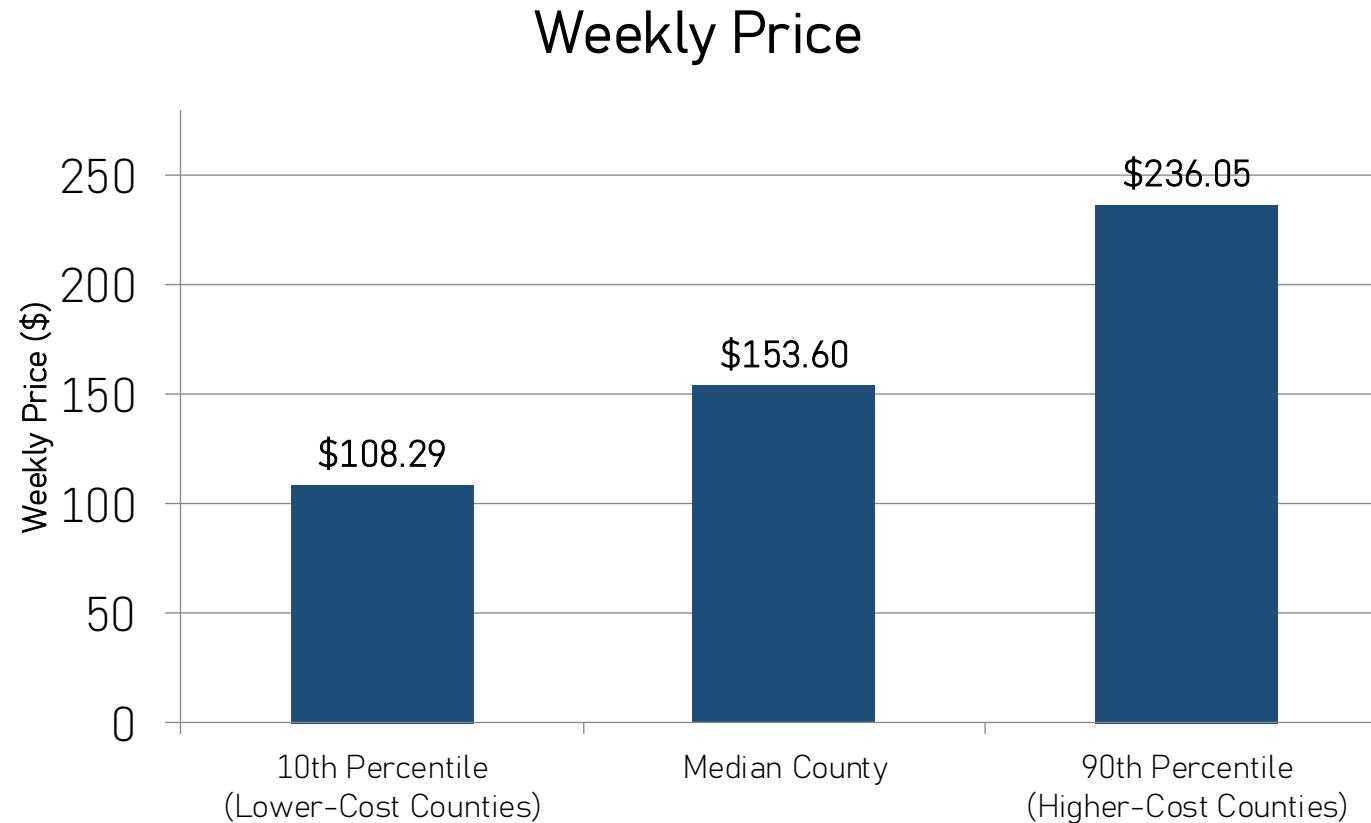


# Center-Based Care Usually Costs More



- *Price gap between center-based and family childcare by age group, 2018*

# Where You Live Changes What Families Pay



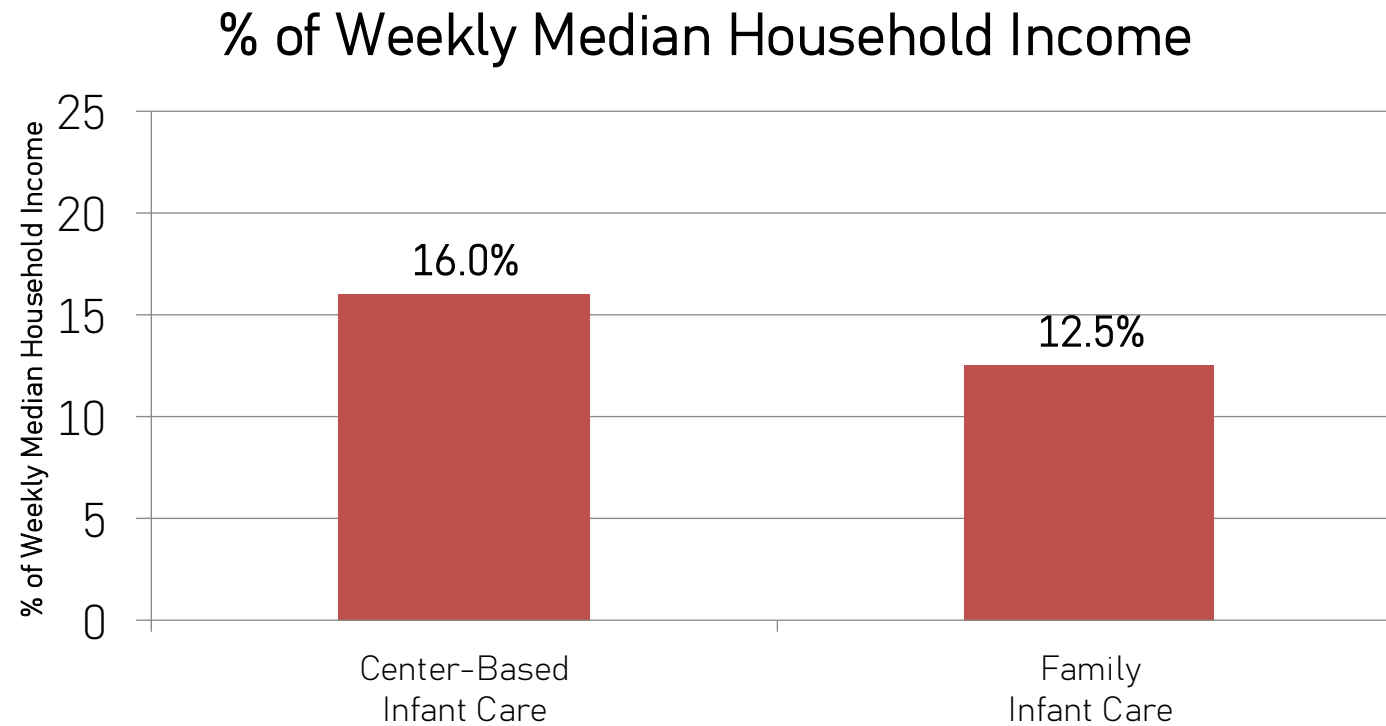
- *Center-based infant care: county price distribution, 2018*

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*The gap between lower-cost and higher-cost counties is more than \$127 per week for center-based infant care alone.*



# Where You Live Changes What Families Pay



- Infant care as a share of estimated weekly median household income, 2018*

*Based on county median household income (\$49,888 annually / ~\$959 weekly). This is county-level context, not a household-specific affordability calculation.*

Even one childcare payment can take a meaningful share of local household earnings.

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# What Parents Can Do with This Information

## Plan

Plan earlier for the infant and toddler years, when weekly costs are highest

## Compare

Compare provider types, not just one advertised price

## Use

Use county-level price data when planning work schedules and childcare transitions

## Bring

Bring local numbers into conversations about flexibility, family budgets, and support needs

Knowing the local price pattern helps families plan, compare, and advocate earlier.

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# What Employers and Local Leaders Should Hear

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When childcare prices are highest in the early years and vary widely by county, support options matter. Possible responses include:

Flexible scheduling for parents of infants and toddlers

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Dependent-care benefits and pre-tax accounts

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Childcare assistance programs

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Stronger local attention where prices are highest

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Childcare affordability acts like a work constraint for many families.



# What This Dataset Does Not Show

- These data show prices, not childcare slot availability
- They do not include informal care from relatives or friends
- Some values were standardized or imputed during dataset construction
- County estimates do not equal every family's exact experience

The technical guide notes that price standardization and imputation can overestimate or underestimate true prices in some cases (U.S. DOL Women's Bureau, 2020).

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# Use the Dashboard for Your County

- This presentation shows the broad pattern. The dashboard lets users explore:
- State and county selection
- Year-over-year trends (2008–2018)
- Provider type comparison
- Age group breakdown
- Price percentile views
- Imputation notes and data quality flags



Dashboard QR Code  
(mock)

Use local childcare price data when asking for flexibility, benefits, or support.